Who Bore the Strain? Faculty vs. Administrative Compensation Trends

Sam English

2026-10-14

Introduction

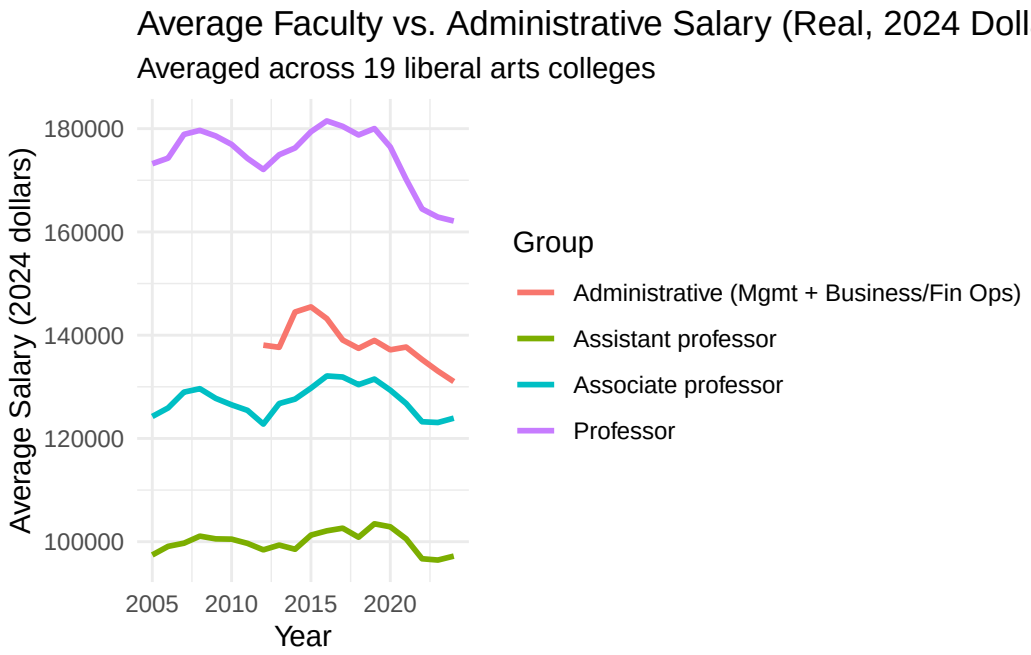
Administrative staffing and spending at U.S. colleges has grown faster than instructional staffing over recent decades, a trend often described as "administrative bloat" in higher education discourse (Ginsberg 2011). This raises the question of which group, faculty or administrators, has been prioritized in institutional budgets over time. This analysis compares real, inflation-adjusted average compensation for faculty and administrative staff across a panel of liberal arts colleges from 2005 to 2024, to see how each group's pay has evolved relative to the other over this period.

Data & Methods

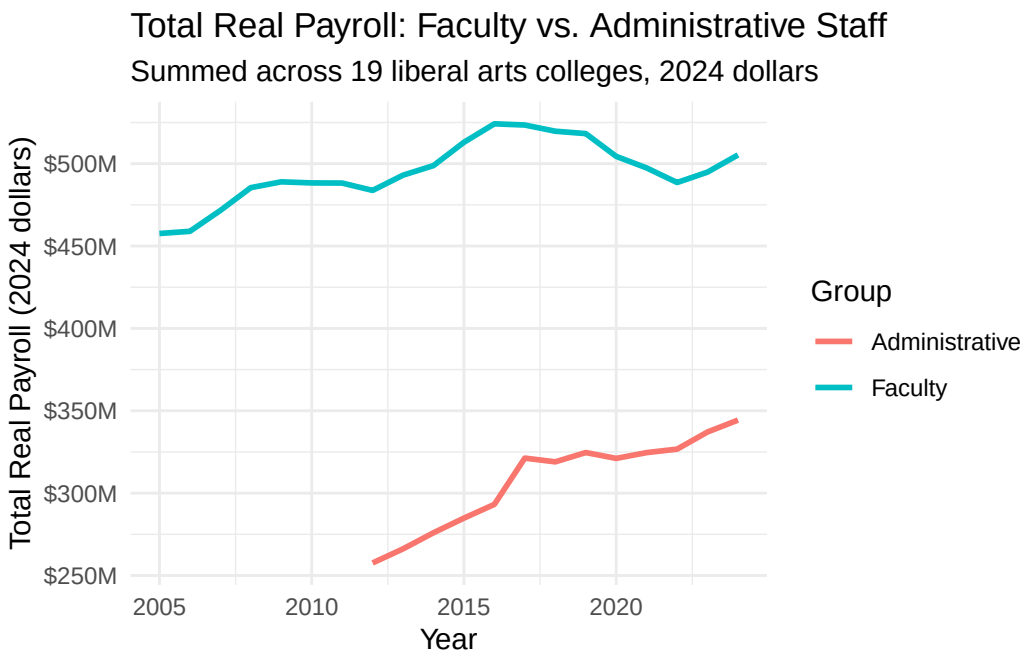
Salary and staffing data come from IPEDS (National Center for Education Statistics 2024) (via the educationdata R package), pulled annually for faculty (2005–2024) and administrative staff (2012–2024) across a list 19 liberal arts colleges, provided by Professor Steinberger and used by the Pomona College board to compare the school with the "most similar" institutions across the country. This analysis is preliminary and focuses on institution-level averages within each staff category; it does not yet disaggregate administrative staff into specific subroles (e.g., senior executives versus general administrative/business staff) or faculty by tenure status, which is planned as a later extension using IPEDS's tenure-status headcount tables and named-compensation data from IRS Form 990 filings. Because IPEDS reports overlapping, inconsistently coded aggregate categories across years, each institution-year observation was resolved by selecting the single row with the largest reported staff count, rather than summing across categories, to avoid double-counting. All dollar figures were converted to 2024 dollars using a CPI deflator built from BLS data (U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics 2024), so that changes over time reflect real compensation rather than nominal growth or inflation. This approach to constructing comparable staffing and compensation categories from IPEDS over

time follows the methodological precedent set by prior work on administrative cost growth in higher education (Hedrick, Wassell, and Henson 2009; Desrochers and Kirshstein 2014).

Results



All four groups show relatively stable real compensation from 2005 through 2019, with a modest dip a few years after the 2008 recession appearing across every group. The clearest shift comes after 2020: every group's real compensation declines, but full professors see the steepest drop, falling from roughly $178,000 in 2019 to about $162,000 by 2024 (a decline of roughly 9%), compared to a roughly 5% decline for administrative staff over the same period. This suggests that administrative compensation was comparatively protected relative to faculty compensation during the COVID-19 shock. This is consistent with the "administrative bloat" narrative that motivated this analysis: it suggests institutions prioritized administrative capacity over instructional capacity during this period of financial stress. A paired t-test comparing each institution's percent change in real compensation from 2019 to 2021 confirms this gap is statistically significant: faculty's decline was on average 3.4 percentage points larger than administrators' ($t(18) = -2.34$, $p = 0.031$, 95% CI: -6.46 to -0.35 percentage points). Average per-person pay, however, doesn't capture whether a growing number of administrators means total administrative spending is rising even as individual pay falls. To test this directly, total real payroll for each group is examined next.



Total real payroll tells a different story than per-person averages. Faculty total payroll rose from about $457.6 million in 2005 to a peak of roughly $524.2 million in 2016, then fell to about $488.6 million by 2022 before partially recovering to $505.3 million in 2024 — a net increase of only 4.5% from 2012 to 2024. Administrative total payroll rose steadily from about $257.6 million in 2012 to roughly $344.3 million in 2024, an increase of 33.7% over that same window, more than seven times faculty's growth rate. The contrast is sharpest between 2016 and 2022, spanning the COVID-19 period: faculty total payroll fell by about 6.8% over those years, while administrative total payroll continued rising by about 11.4%. Taken together with the per-person findings above, this suggests that administrative bloat is more visible in headcount-driven total spending than in individual compensation: administrators were not, on average, paid dramatically more than before, but there were enough more of them that total administrative spending kept growing while total faculty spending stagnated and even declined.

Limitations

This analysis has several limitations. IPEDS's administrative staff category aggregates a range of distinct roles (management and business/financial operations) that may mask heterogeneity within the group. The sample is limited to 19 liberal arts colleges and may not generalize to other institution types. Compensation has not yet been adjusted for regional cost of living. While the paired t-test above is statistically significant, it is based on a small sample of 19 institutions, which limits its statistical power and the precision of the reported confidence

interval; a more robust panel regression accounting for institution-specific factors is planned for the final analysis.

References

Desrochers, Donna M., and Rita Kirshstein. 2014. "Labor Intensive or Labor Expensive? Changing Staffing and Compensation Patterns in Higher Education." Delta Cost Project, American Institutes for Research. https://www.air.org/sites/default/files/downloads/report/DeltaCostAIR-Labor-Expensive-Higher-Education-Staffing-Brief-Feb2014.pdf.

Ginsberg, Benjamin. 2011. *The Fall of the Faculty: The Rise of the All-Administrative University and Why It Matters*. Oxford University Press.

Hedrick, David W., Charles S. Wassell, and Steven E. Henson. 2009. "Administrative Costs in Higher Education: How Fast Are They Really Growing?" *Education Economics* 17 (1): 123–37.

National Center for Education Statistics. 2024. "Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS)." U.S. Department of Education. https://nces.ed.gov/ipeds/.

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. 2024. "Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers: All Items (CUUR0000SA0)." https://www.bls.gov/cpi/.